

HIGH AND LOW NEGATION IN SPANISH STRIPPING

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1. Introduction

• **Stripping** (Hankamer & Sag 1976) involves a sentence coordinated with an XP preceded by an adverbial element. We focus on cases where the adverbial is *no*:

- (1) Llegó Sonia, pero no Bruno. (2) Llegó Sonia, no Bruno.
arrived Sonia but not Bruno arrived Sonia not Bruno
'Sonia arrived, but not Bruno.' 'Sonia arrived, not Bruno.'

• Spanish Stripping involves an **elliptical clause** where the remnant and negation survive deletion (Depiante 2000, Saab 2008, Muñoz Pérez & Stigliano 2026):

- (3) [_{NP} [_{CP} Llegó Sonia] [_& { $\emptyset$ | pero} [_{CP} no Llegó Bruno]

• The literature usually takes the conjunction *pero* ('but') to be optional (i.e., there is a single structure in which it may surface or not).

We challenge the assumption that the conjunction is optional, and argue that examples such as (1) and (2) instantiate **two distinct syntactic structures**:

- ✓ Negation in *pero*-NEG-XP patterns like (1) is clause-internal.
- ✓ Negation in NEG-XP patterns like (2) is clause-external.

3. The distribution of *pero*

• Vicente (2006), Kolokonte (2008): remnant in NEG-XP stripping is a contrastive focus. In Rooth's (1992) system, this interpretation arises when the f-value of α contains a previously uttered proposition β :

- ➔ For Spanish NEG-XP stripping, $\llbracket \beta \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f$ is satisfied only if negation is not taken as part of the propositional content of α .

→ this follows straightforwardly if *no* in these configurations is not part of α :

→ we claim that *no* is, then, **high negation**

- (12) a. [_{β} Llegó Sonia], no [_{α} Llegó BRUNO_F]. cf. (2)
b. $\llbracket \beta \rrbracket^o = \text{Sonia arrived}$
c. $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f = \{x \text{ arrived} \mid x \in D_e\}$
d. $\llbracket \beta \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f$

• As for *pero*-NEG-XP stripping, we take it that the distribution of *pero* follows from its information structural requirements:

- ➔ The conjunction *pero* requires to link two clauses, each containing a pair of constituents that contrast with their counterparts in the other clause.
- ➔ Extending Kolokonte's (2008) characterization of *pero*-NEG-XP patterns, we take it that both NEG and XP are focused:
→ this is a *multiple focus* construction (Krifka 1992).

• We follow Constant (2014) in assuming that structures with two foci can give rise to nested alternatives sets, i.e., sets of question in the sense that Büring (2003) associates with contrastive topics. The core intuition then is that a *pero*-NEG-XP pattern evokes a set of alternative questions:

- (13) a. Llegó Sonia, pero [_{α} NO_F Llegó BRUNO_F]. cf. (1)
b. $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f = \{\{\text{POL}(x \text{ arrived}) \mid x \in D_e\} \mid \text{POL} \in D_{\{+, -\}}\}$
= $\{\text{who arrived?}, \text{who didn't arrive?}\}$

• Since *pero* requires *no* to be part of the computation of propositional alternatives, it follows that the latter cannot be an instance of high negation.

- (14) **GENERALIZATION ON THE DISTRIBUTION OF *pero***
In sequences of the form *pero no* ('but not') in Spanish stripping clauses, *no* ('not') is always an instance of (low) propositional negation.

5. Conclusions and open questions

• In Spanish stripping, *pero* is not optional. Examples with/without this conjunction instantiate two distinct syntactic structures.

• Identifying the split between **NEG-XP** and ***pero*-NEG-XP** configurations is crucial for the study of (Spanish) stripping:

- ✓ Without it, examples from different configurations can be conflated, leading to contradictory reports about the behavior of the construction.
- ✓ A structural distinction in terms of **high vs. low negation** provides a clearer empirical basis for future work on the construction.

• Open question: What's ellipsis-specific and what can be generalized to non-elliptical contexts? Is high negation only available in contexts of ellipsis?

2. High negation in Spanish stripping

• If *pero* were truly optional, acceptability contrasts such as (4) vs. (5) would be unexpected:

- (4) No llegó SONIA, no Bruno. (5) *No llegó SONIA, pero no Bruno.
not arrived Sonia not Bruno not arrived Sonia but not Bruno
'Sonia didn't arrive, not Bruno.' 'Sonia didn't arrive, but not Bruno.'
→ *Sonia didn't arrive, Bruno (maybe) did.*

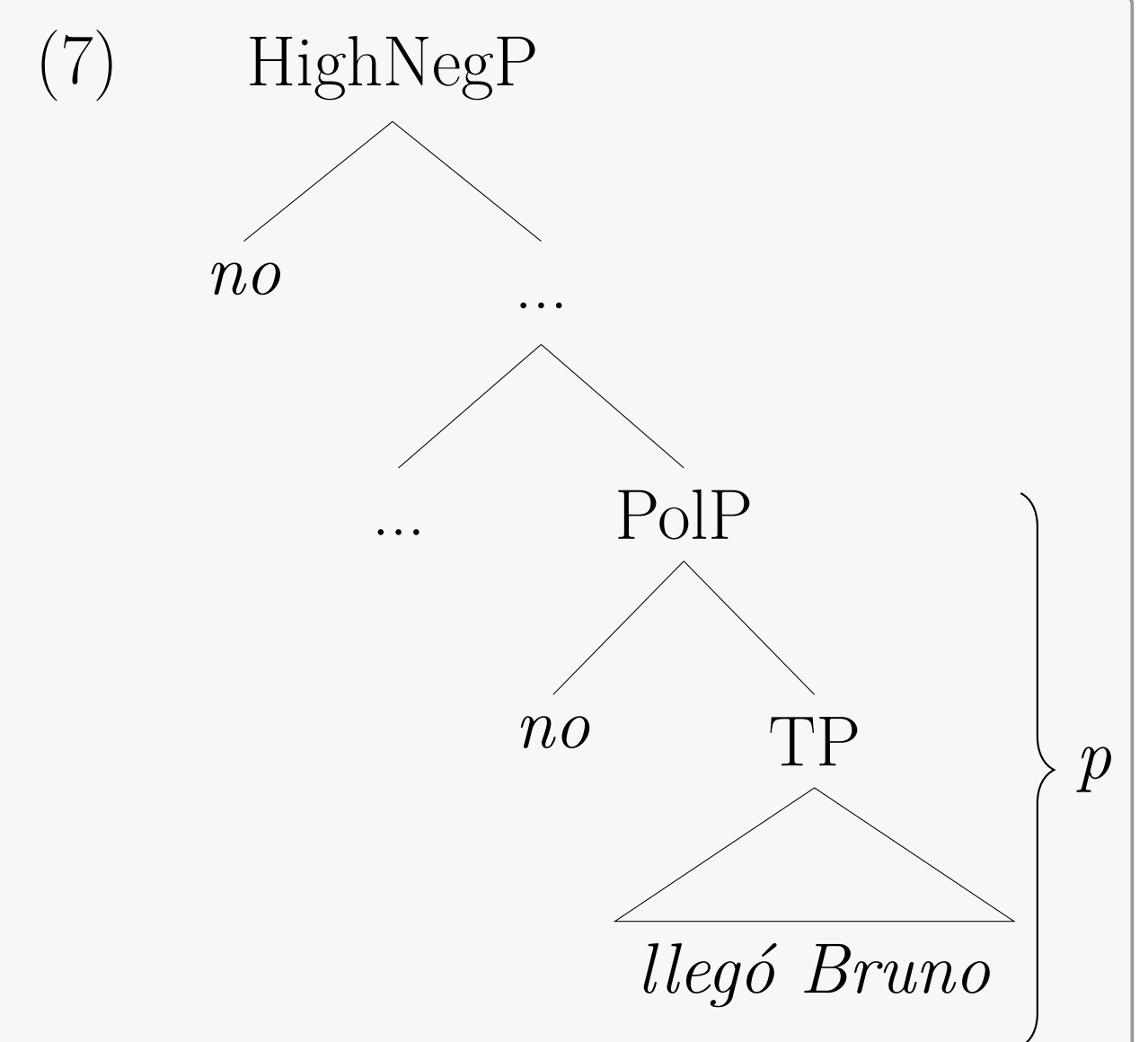
• The interpretation in (4) requires an underlying representation containing **two negations**:

- (6) No llegó SONIA, no ~~no~~ llegó Bruno.
not arrived Sonia not not arrived Bruno

• Since propositional negation cannot iterate or "stack" in this manner (Collins 2018), one of these negative elements must be of a **different type**:

- ➔ we claim that the overt *no* in Spanish NEG-XP configurations realizes **high negation**.
- ➔ high negation is an operator that affects the **illocutionary** status of the sentence rather than its propositional content (Repp 2013, Romero 2015, Goodhue 2022).

1. High negation occupies a **clause-external position** in the left periphery of the sentence.
2. Unlike standard propositional negation in PolP, high negation is **truth-conditionally vacuous**.
3. High Negation scopes over an **assertion operator assert** that combines with the proposition (Goodhue 2022), which yields $\neg \text{ASSERT}(p)$.
4. Accordingly, the elliptical structure in (4) roughly means '*it is not the case that the speaker is committed to the claim that Bruno didn't arrive.*'
5. NEG-XP stripping structures recruiting high negation function as **illocutionary denials**.



• This analysis is supported by the interaction of necessity modals and negation:

- ➔ negation + modal (e.g., *no debe* 'not must') can be interpreted as either $\neg > \Box$ or $\Box > \neg$
- ➔ *pero*-NEG-XP stripping displays this ambiguity:

- (8) Sonia debe subir de peso, pero no Bruno. (9) [_{HighNegP} ... [_{PolP} *no* [_{TP} debe
Sonia must go.up of weight but not Bruno $\uparrow$ $\uparrow$
'Sonia must gain weight, but not Bruno.' *covert movement*

✓ $\neg > \Box$, ✓ $\Box > \neg$

• NEG-XP stripping is unambiguously interpreted with negation taking scope over the modal:

- (10) Sonia debe subir de peso, no Bruno. (11) [_{HighNegP} *no* ... [_{PolP} Pol [_{TP} debe
Sonia must go.up of weight not Bruno $\uparrow$ $\uparrow$
'Sonia must gain weight, not Bruno.' $\times$ $\uparrow$
✓ $\neg > \Box$, $\times \Box > \neg$ *covert movement*

- ➔ This follows if covert movement of the modal (Iatridou & Zeijlstra 2013) cannot reach positions that are external to the proposition (11).

4. Differences between NEG-XP and *pero*-NEG-XP

• The analyses in (12) and (13), which hinge on whether negation is part of the proposition or not, account for several contrasts between NEG-XP and *pero*-NEG-XP configurations:

- (15) Vino alguien, pero no Sonia. (16) *Vino alguien, no Sonia.
came somebody but not Sonia came somebody not Sonia
'Somebody came, but not Sonia.' 'Somebody came, but not Sonia.'

- ➔ On the one hand, the *pero*-NEG-XP configuration in (15) raises the issue of who the person who came is. This is straightforwardly captured under our analysis, as it predicts that an implicit question (i.e., *who came?*) remains unanswered:

- (17) a. Vino alguien, pero [_{α} NO_F $\forall \text{H}\emptyset$ SONIA_F]
b. $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f = \{\{\text{POL}(x \text{ came}) \mid x \in D_e\} \mid \text{POL} \in D_{\{+, -\}}\}$
= $\{\text{who came?}, \text{who didn't come?}\}$

• By contrast, in the unacceptable NEG-XP configuration in (16), the condition on contrastive foci (i.e., $\llbracket \beta \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f$) is not satisfied, therefore the sentence is unacceptable:

- (18) a. [_{β} Vino alguien], no [_{α} $\forall \text{H}\emptyset$ SONIA_F] c. $\llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f = \{x \text{ came} \mid x \in D_e\}$
b. $\llbracket \beta \rrbracket^o = \text{Somebody came}$ d. $\llbracket \beta \rrbracket^o \notin \llbracket \alpha \rrbracket^f$

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